Representation by Any Means: Public Expectations of Congress in Light of Executive Policymaking

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Abstract

As presidents increasingly rely on unilateral powers to create policy, do Americans still demand legislative action from their representatives? This question is of critical importance in an era of expansive presidential power coupled with a legislative branch often reluctant or unable to respond to executive action. In this research note, we employ a survey experiment that randomly varies the intensity with which legislators support or oppose an action taken by President Trump. We find that citizens supportive of the president are indifferent as to the congressional response. Opponents of the president, however, reward a more active response from lawmakers in opposition to the president. Our findings illuminate how representation works in the modern era, illustrate how separation-of-powers dynamics condition the public's relationship with their legislators, and help explain an historic lack of productivity in the contemporary Congress.

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The contemporary American presidency is defined by unilateral action. Modern presidents have embraced their unilateral policymaking tools, often aided by a Congress either supportive of these actions or unwilling or unable to respond (Bailey and Rottinghaus 2014; Djourelova and Durante 2022; Howell 2003). These trends are exemplified by President Trump and the 119th Congress. Trump took an expansive approach to the use of presidential power as he began his second term in office; the first 100 days were marked by the signing of 142 executive orders, surpassing Franklin D. Roosevelt's previous record of 99 in his first 100 days.[1] Trump's robust use of unilateral action resulted in transformative changes across American government, including on immigration, tariffs, energy, foreign policy, and the size and structure of the federal bureaucracy.

Public and media reactions to Trump's use of executive power were mixed, yet the congressional response remained relatively consistent.[2] With few exceptions, Republican lawmakers deferred to the president's actions and were reluctant to exercise their own policymaking capabilities on the same issues. These unilateral policy changes implemented early in Trump's second term occurred as Republicans held a majority in both chambers of Congress. While these majorities could have plausibly codified many of the president's actions into law, the standard response from congressional Republicans was one of support without any steps toward their own formal action.[3]

While others have endeavored to explain the conditions under which presidents take unilateral action (see Lowande and Rogowski 2021), we seek to explain why Congress allows it. In this research note, we investigate one explanation for the lack of legislative response to an expansion of executive power: the incentives created by the public. We argue that supporters of a president desire policy representation "by any means" and are indifferent as to whether their copartisans in Congress take active steps to legislate on the outcomes the president achieves unilaterally, so long

[1]"2025 Donald J. Trump Executive Orders," *Federal Register*.

[2]For examples of media responses, see this *Wall Street Journal* editorial, or this *New York Times* editorial.

[3]This is despite the president's encroachment on core congressional powers, such as appropriation (Kriner 2026).

as their desired outcome is realized. Contrastingly, we expect that opponents of the president will demand a more active legislative response from Congress and reward resistance to unsatisfactory unilateral policymaking.

To test our argument, we conducted two complementary survey experiments on a Census-targeted national sample of 2,000 Americans in April 2025—roughly two and a half months into the second Trump presidency. Our experiments assess how varying degrees of active action from a member of Congress in response to policymaking by the president are associated with constituent evaluations of the legislator. On the whole, our findings provide support for our argument. We find that citizens who are copartisans of Trump are indifferent to the method of implementation of such action. Citizens do not have a preference for whether the president is solely responsible for such an action or whether a legislator follows the president's lead to codify his unilateral action into law. In other words, supporters of the president hold preferences about outcomes—policy representation "by any means"—and care very little about who receives credit for achieving the policy victory, even if it departs from regular constitutional order. Citizens who oppose the president, however, have a preference for legislators taking active steps to counter Trump's unilateral actions. In this sense, presidential outpartisans desire any attempts to resist what they view as a policy worthy of objection.

We also study the impact of this behavior on evaluations of the president and Congress as an institution. Legislative responses from both sides of the aisle have the capacity to polarize how outpartisans evaluate the president. Copartisan action in support of the president appears to legitimize the policy actions of the president and increase support for the president, while outpartisan opposition to the president further suppresses support. We find null results for evaluations of Congress at large.

Our findings have implications for our understanding of representation, accountability, and the separation of powers in the modern era. The asymmetric demand for lawmaking across partisans indicates that it is rational for members of Congress who are copartisans of a president

engaging in assertive unilateral actions to save their efforts and legislative capital and ride the coattails of the president. Outpartisans who oppose the expansion of executive power, on the other hand, have electoral (in addition to institutional) incentives to continue their legislative efforts to reassert Congress' dominance.[4]

Policymaking, Representation, and the Separation of Powers

The relationship between the American public and members of Congress lies at the heart of American representative democracy. Citizens are attentive to how their legislators act in office across a range of substantive and symbolic behaviors, including voting (Ansolabehere and Kuriwaki 2022; Bovitz and Carson 2006), position taking (Dietrich and Hayes 2023), and handling of procedural and institutional tasks (Bass, Cameron, and Kastellec 2022; Badas and Simas 2022; Kriner and Schickler 2014). In an increasingly polarized environment in which unorthodox procedures are frequently employed to achieve partisan victories (Sinclair 2016; Curry 2015), members have fewer opportunities to develop records distinct from that of the party (Lee 2016).

Fundamentally, voters demand policy representation from their elected representatives (Ansolabehere and Kuriwaki 2022). When legislators are in the minority and locked out of much of the lawmaking process, voters reward attempts to obstruct the majority agenda (Patty 2016; Stone 2024). While there remain some benefits to pursuing bipartisan outcomes (Case, Ommundsen, and Porter 2025), the public often prefers partisan wins over compromise (Case and Ommundsen 2024; Harbridge, Malhotra, and Harrison 2014). Ultimately, however, the public has a clear preference for realized outcomes over legislative gridlock (Flynn and Harbridge 2016; Jones and McDermott 2010).

While Congress is an inherently collaborative body where coalition building is often necessary to overcome procedural hurdles and craft new policy, the president is afforded many tools

[4]Hamilton, *Federalist 51*.

to make policy without involving Congress. Research paints a mixed picture of how the American public reacts to unilateral presidential policymaking. One strain of research concludes that the American public exhibits a general antipathy to the use of unilateral action (Reeves and Rogowski 2022*a*,*b*), while other scholarship finds either that these attitudes are pliable in particular contexts (Christenson and Kriner 2017*a*; Reeves and Rogowski 2016; Reeves et al. 2017) or that the public is indifferent towards its use (Goehring and Lowande 2025).

In this paper, we answer two questions that remain unaddressed by extant work. First, does the American public's satisfaction with policy outcomes vary depending on the branch responsible for achieving the outcome? And second, how does assertive action from the president shape what the public expects from their members of Congress? While research has addressed how actions from one branch of government condition evaluations of another (e.g., Kriner and Schickler 2014; Reeves and Rogowski 2022*b*), this work does not speak to how the public evaluates Congress in a context in which the president has taken clear control of the policymaking process. This question is of fundamental importance in the contemporary era of American politics. To be certain, Trump's second term in office underscores the need to understand how the public responds to presidential policymaking and congressional inaction, yet these developments are not unique to President Trump, nor his political party. The unilateral assertiveness of presidents of both parties has increased over the past few decades (Howell 2003; Lowande 2014; Moe and Howell 1999) and presidents are strategic in using these powers to avoid congressional sanction (Bailey and Rottinghaus 2014; Djourelova and Durante 2022). In an era of gridlock and polarization in Congress, this appears unlikely to abate. Answering these questions provides essential insight into representation and institutional power in the contemporary American political landscape.

Building upon perspectives from extant scholarship, we develop expectations about how a president active in policymaking will shape how the American public evaluates the role of lawmakers. Most simply, the public should shape their evaluations of the behavior of Congress

according to their level of agreement with the president's realized outcome. First and foremost, we expect that the public demands policy representation and cares more about the overall policy output from government than which particular actor secures it: representation "by any means." The public is accepting of unilateral presidential policymaking when it secures desired policy outcomes (Reeves et al. 2017), so we expect that unilateral action will lead copartisans of the president to demand less in terms of active policymaking from their members of Congress. They may still demand and reward legislative action from their representatives (Ansolabehere and Kuriwaki 2022), but we expect that the fulfillment of policy demands from one branch may lead to a substitution of those demands for the other branch. On the other hand, we anticipate outpartisans of the president will oppose unilateral action and reward members of Congress who work to oppose such behavior. Dissatisfied with the policy outputs of government, opponents of the president should reward legislative effort to push back against unilateral policymaking.

We also expect that the actions of members of Congress may shape how individuals evaluate the president and the role of Congress. Extant research illustrates the capacity of institutional actors to shape evaluations of the other branches and institutional powers (Kriner and Schickler 2014; Rogowski and Stone 2021). When Congress seeks to exercise oversight or control over the executive branch, this has the capacity to shape what the public knows about the president and Congress as an institution and how it can respond to an assertive presidential policymaker.

Experimental Design

To study how the American public evaluates the actions of members of Congress in the context of active presidential policymaking, we employ two preregistered survey experiments.[5] We conducted our survey from April 3–8, 2025 with the survey firm Verasight, which provided us with a sample of 2,000 American adult respondents quota-targeted to match U.S. Census

[5]For discussion of our pre-analysis plan, see Appendix Section C.

demographics.[6] Descriptive statistics on our respondents are presented in Appendix Table A.2.

The timing of our study provides a number of benefits for answering our research questions. Our survey was fielded roughly two and a half months into the second Trump presidency. While the use of unilateral authorities is not unique to President Trump, this time period was characterized by a marked increase in the frequency of presidential policymaking. This allows us to study how the public evaluates congressional responses to such presidential behavior in the midst of a real-world environment where these issues were salient. To further increase the realism of our design, in building our treatments we draw upon how members of Congress communicated about the Trump administration in their public-facing messaging during this time period; see Appendix Section B for specific examples.

We presented each of our respondents with both experiments, randomizing the order of experiments to avoid systematic spillover effects. In the first, we presented respondents with one of four messages from a hypothetical Republican senator to their constituents that varies the extent to which the member of Congress is active or passive in supporting President Trump's agenda; in the second, we presented similar messages from a hypothetical Democratic senator in opposition to Trump. These dueling frames allow us to construct plausible treatments where members do or do not seek to employ legislative measures in support of or opposition to the president. Further, our setup is a realistic reflection of how the public learns about the behavior of their members of Congress: legislators craft public communications such as press releases, social media posts, and e-newsletters with their constituents in mind (Green et al. 2024; Russell 2021). Even if the public does not view these messages directly, they are typical of a legislator's overall communication strategy and are covered by the media (Grimmer 2013), shaping constituent evaluations (Rogowski and Stone 2020).

Our first experiment focuses on reactions to executive policymaking from members of Congress

[6]Verasight recruited our survey takers from its pool of over 200,000 Americans. They take steps to ensure high-quality human responses; please see Appendix Section A.2 for more details.

who are copartisans of the president. All respondents were presented with an introductory prompt informing respondents about Republican party control of Congress, ensuring all respondents were aware of relevant institutional arrangements at the time of the survey. Then, all respondents received a message from a hypothetical Republican senator from a state similar to their own about reducing waste and fraud in the federal government. This was one of the most salient political issues at the time of the survey and a defining aspect of the second Trump administration's first few months in office.[7]

All respondents received a general statement of support for the Trump administration's actions from a Republican legislator. Non-control respondents also received one of three treatments that incorporated additional actions from the senator: (1) a vocal display of support, (2) an indication that the senator introduced legislation on the issue, or (3) a discussion of the success of the senator's introduced legislation on the issue. This setup allows us to assess how Americans react to different actions of members of Congress requiring varying degrees of effort in response to executive policymaking behavior. For illustration, Figure 1 depicts the control vignette with the second treatment option (introduced legislation) bolded in brackets. After reading the vignette, respondents answered five-point outcome questions capturing evaluations of the legislator, President Trump, and the institutional role of Congress in supporting the president. Table A.1 presents excerpts of the treatment language, for full details on treatment and outcome question wordings, see Appendix Section A.3.

Our second experiment assesses how the public reacts to responses to executive policymaking from presidential outpartisans in Congress. Respondents received the same introductory prompt discussed above, followed by a message from a hypothetical Democratic senator in opposition to the Trump administration's actions. Non-control respondents also received one of three treatments that discussed additional actions: (1) a vocal display of opposition, (2) the introduction of

[7]Consider The American Presidency Project's assessment that, "The most effective and disruptive elements of the first 100 days have been achieved through DOGE—the Department of Government Efficiency," whose mandate was to cut spending and regulation (Woolley and Peters 2025).

FIGURE 1: Survey Vignette Example

As you know, President Trump won the 2024 election and took office in January 2025. Additionally, Republicans are in control of both chambers of Congress. Imagine that a Republican U.S. Senator who represents a state similar to yours sent the following letter to members of your community last week. Please read the statement carefully.

Dear Neighbor,

Thank you for taking the time to read about my work to serve as your Senator.

One of my top priorities as your representative in Washington is cutting government waste. In recent years, waste and fraud has taken hold of the federal government.

[In just the past month I introduced a new bill, the Prevent Taxpayer Waste Act, that takes steps to identify and cut waste out of federal agencies. I urge my colleagues to support this bill.]

Republicans are working with President Trump and his administration to take action, and we won't stop fighting to bring the federal government's spending spree to a halt and uphold the rule of law.

I will continue to work to support our country's needs every day.

Note: Figure presents one possible survey vignette respondents were exposed to in the copartisan in Congress experiment. Bold text and brackets (added for emphasis) denote one of three possible actions from the senator.

legislation on the issue, or (3) a stronger attempt to legislate by also meeting with colleagues and urging them to support the bill. Excerpts of the treatments are presented in Table A.1 and full language in Appendix Section A.3. We sought to keep the message language parallel across the two experiments such that the primary differences were the partisanship of the legislator and the degree of effort exerted in their reaction. Respondents answered five-point outcome questions identical to those in the first experiment, with one variation: we asked about the role of Congress in opposing (rather than supporting) the president.

Results

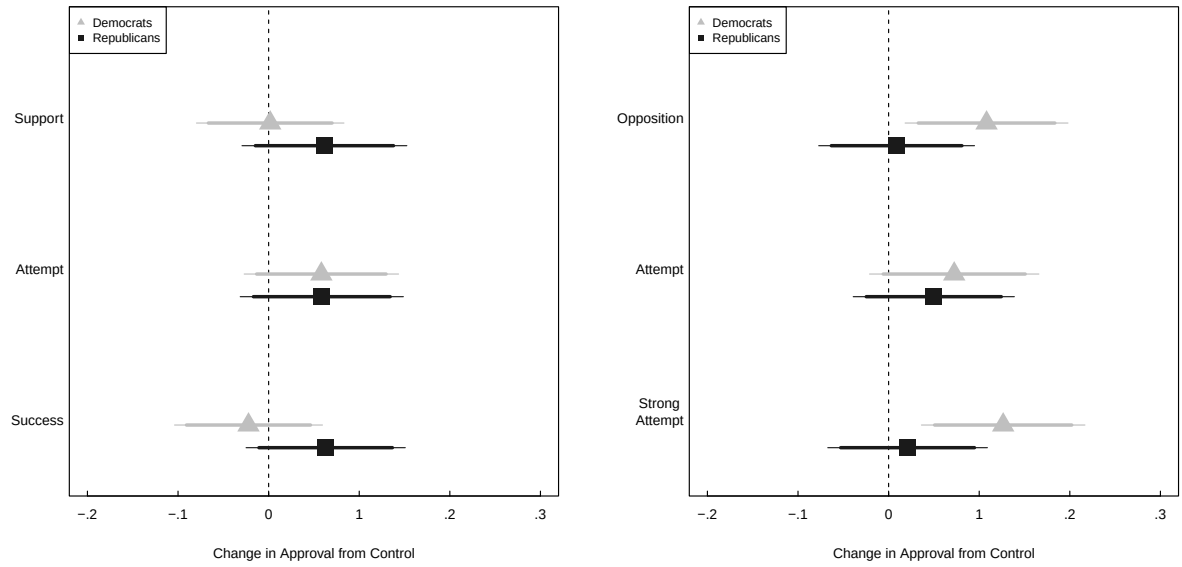
We begin by assessing the relationship between legislator behavior and constituent approval of the legislator. In Figure 2, we present the treatment effects (estimated by differences-in-means) of each legislator statement compared to the control condition of general support of (left panel) or opposition to (right panel) the president. We report separate effects for copartisans and outpartisans. In the first experiment, we do not find clear evidence that actions taken by copartisans of the president in Congress to support the president's policymaking are associated with changed support for the legislator. Democrats (outpartisans of the president and legislator in this experiment) appear generally unmoved by these actions in comparison to the control. The treatment effects for Republicans are positive, but not statistically distinguishable from zero (with p-values ranging from 0.16 to 0.20). In line with our expectations, we find that there is no electoral incentive for presidential copartisans to take active steps to codify unilaterally created policy into law, as constituents remain satisfied by the president's policymaking and unmoved by a legislative response.

We do, however, find evidence that actions taken by outpartisans of the president in Congress (the second experiment) generate increases in approval of the legislator among Democrats (who share a partisan identity with the legislator in this experiment). The statement of opposition is associated with a 10.8 percentage point increase in support (p=.02), as compared with the control, while the strong legislative attempt (introducing legislation and seeking meetings to urge cosponsorship) is associated with a 12.6 percentage point increase in support (p=.01). We do not find distinguishable effects for the general attempt to legislate. We also find no clear distinguishable effects among Republicans in this experiment (here, outpartisans of the legislator).

In sum, across the two experiments, we do not find evidence that respondents who are copartisans of the president are moved by the legislative actions of members of Congress; they remain satisfied by the outcome achieved by the president and indifferent toward any particular

FIGURE 2: Legislator Action and Approval of Legislator

(a) Experiment 1 (Support for President) **(b)** Experiment 2 (Opposition to President)



Note: Left panel shows estimated treatment effects on binary approval of Republican legislators as function of legislator action as compared to control statement. Right panel shows estimated treatment effects on binary approval of Democratic legislators as function of legislator action as compared to control statement. Separate treatment effects plotted for Democratic (light gray triangles) and Republican (dark gray squares) respondents. 90 and 95 percent confidence intervals plotted for each estimate.

attempt to codify the policy. On the other hand, we find that outpartisans of the president reward their copartisans for actively standing up to the president.[8] These findings are consistent with our expectations: copartisans of the president are satisfied by the policy outcome, regardless of who is responsible for its success, and outparisans of the president reward steps to push back on presidential policymaking.

In additional analyses presented in the Appendix, we consider how the treatments are associated with legislator evaluations along two other dimensions: evaluations that the legislator works on behalf of constituents like them and prospective vote choice. We find that copartisans of the legislator in both experiments are more likely to evaluate the legislator as working hard on

[8]We find similar results when using a five-point measure of approval (Figure D.3) and when dropping middle-ground ("neither approve nor disapprove") respondents (Figure D.4).

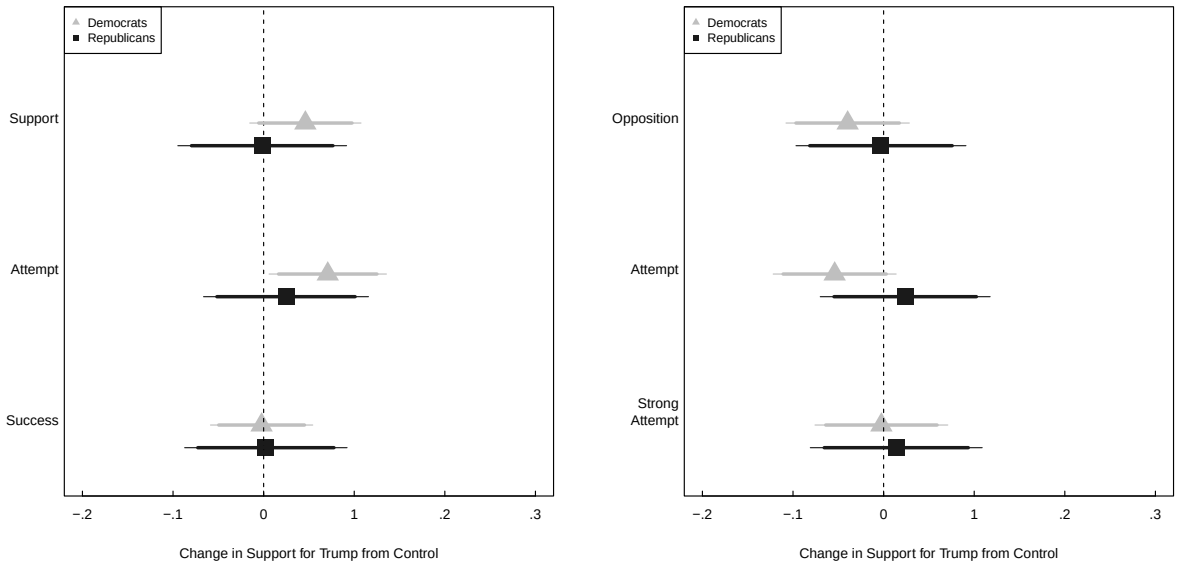
behalf of constituents like them if they take action compared to the control; results for outpartisans of the legislator are null (see Figure D.1). In combination with the results for our approval outcome variable, these findings illustrate that while presidential copartisans recognize the effort that same-party legislators devote to policymaking, these efforts do not translate to increased approval. This suggests challenges for the president's copartisans in Congress seeking to build a personal lawmaking brand in a policymaking environment where the president is in control. Further, across both experiments, we find no evidence that legislators can impact vote choice with the actions we study (see Figure D.2). These findings mirror research illustrating that voting behavior is stickier than other forms of constituent evaluations (Dancey, Henderson, and Sheagley 2024), suggesting that members of Congress seeking to improve their electoral prospects might need to take stronger actions than those presented in our treatments.

We turn now to considering how legislator behavior affects views of other political actors. In Figure 3, we demonstrate that the actions of legislators have some impact on presidential outpartisans' evaluations of the president. While baseline levels of support for President Trump among Democrats are very low (across both experimental control conditions, 11.9 percent of Democrats express support), we find evidence that Republican members of Congress engaging in policymaking on the same issues as President Trump is associated with greater outpartisan support of the president. As illustrated in the left panel of the figure, statements of support for the president are associated with a 4.6 percentage point increase (p=.14) in support, and attempts to legislate correspond with a 7.1 percentage point increase (p=.03). This is evidence that the actions of Congress can legitimize presidential policymaking among those skeptical of the president in power, akin to scholarship illustrating the Supreme Court's power to confer policy legitimacy (Mondak 1994).

We do not find clear evidence of the impact of the actions of Democratic members of Congress on how Democrats evaluate the president (right panel). While the estimated treatment effects for the opposition statement and attempt to legislate are negative, they are not statisti-

FIGURE 3: Legislator Action and Approval of Trump

(a) Experiment 1 (Support for President) **(b)** Experiment 2 (Opposition to President)



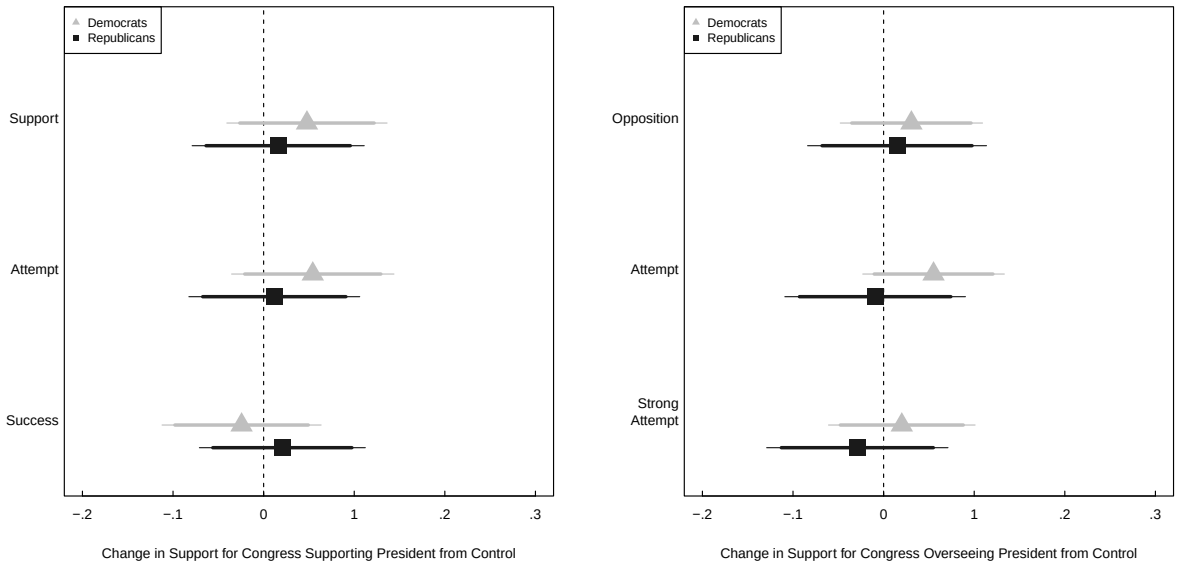
Note: Left panel shows estimated treatment effects on binary approval of Trump as function of legislator action as compared to control statement. Right panel shows estimated treatment effects on binary approval of Trump as function of legislator action as compared to control statement. Separate treatment effects plotted for Democratic (light gray triangles) and Republican (dark gray squares) respondents. 90 and 95 percent confidence intervals plotted for each estimate.

cally distinguishable from zero (p= 0.25 and 0.12, respectively). Further, we find no evidence in either experiment that statements from legislators impact how presidential copartisans (Republican respondents) evaluate the president. This suggests that individual minority party members of Congress may struggle to mobilize their constituents against the president, in comparison to more collective actions taken by Congress (Christenson and Kriner 2017*b*; Kriner and Schickler 2014).

Finally, in Figure 4, we present results showing that the experimental treatments are not associated with changes in how constituents of either party evaluate the role of Congress in responding to the president. The degree to which an individual member of Congress acts in response to presidential policymaking has little effect on the institution's broader reputation.

FIGURE 4: Legislator Action and Evaluations of the Role of Congress

(a) Experiment 1 (Support for President) **(b)** Experiment 2 (Opposition to President)



Note: Left panel shows estimated treatment effects on binary agreement with statement that Congress should actively support the president as function of legislator action as compared to control statement. Right panel shows estimated treatment effects on binary agreement with statement that Congress should actively oversee the president as function of legislator action as compared to control statement. 90 and 95 percent confidence intervals plotted for each estimate.

Discussion and Conclusion

Much has been made in popular commentary about how the modern Congress has ceded its powers to enable copartisan presidents. Our findings illustrate that copartisans of the president in Congress do not benefit from taking active measures to legislate alongside a president who is active in policymaking unilaterally. Thus, electoral and policymaking incentives align in ways that reduce the incentives for majority party lawmakers in unified government to try to build individual lawmaking brands. Our findings illustrate an important consequence of the decreasing number of swing districts: with fewer members needing to rely on the votes of independent and outpartisan constituents to win reelection, most copartisans of the president are incentivized to passively endorse presidential actions rather than actively legislate to protect the congressional prerogative. We thus speak to why copartisans of the president in Congress are accepting of the

growth of unilateral action, even at the expense of congressional power (Kriner 2026).

Nevertheless, we find that presidential out-party respondents reward copartisan lawmakers for taking action to forestall executive branch policymaking. Thus, the minority party has clear electoral incentives to engage in oversight of the executive branch and provide signals to the American public about the behavior of these actors (Kriner and Schickler 2014). Our mixed findings regarding the impact of individual legislator behavior on evaluations of the president and the role of Congress vis-à-vis the president contribute to our understanding of the public's expectations for how Congress and the president exercise their institutional powers (Reeves and Rogowski 2022*a*,*b*; Smith and Park 2013; Stone 2024) and the capacity of actors in one branch of government to shape the public's views of another (Christenson and Kriner 2017*b*).

We note that there are opportunities for future research that our study does not directly address. Under unified government, one important determinant of presidential policymaking success is the extent of party unity the president has from Congress. While the 119th Congress was broadly deferential to the president, Republicans in both chambers at times pushed back against the administration's actions.[9] How might both copartisans and outpartisans of the president react to a same-party legislator that takes action or speaks out against an assertive use of presidential powers? Our treatments involve the actions and statements of one legislator, but party is a primary determinant of member behavior in the modern Congress (Lee 2016). How might individuals respond to statements that more clearly elevate the salience of party unity (e.g., messages from leadership or a joint message from multiple members) or highlight the willingness of individual members to buck the party or engage in bipartisan lawmaking? Providing answers to these questions would further illuminate the incentives lawmakers face when deciding when and how to respond to presidential policymaking.

[9]See, for example, *Associated Press* coverage of congressional oversight of the Department of Defense available here.

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Supplementary Materials

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A Survey Information

A.1 Statement on Ethical Research Principles

This project adheres to the "Principles and Guidance for Human Subjects Research" adopted by the American Political Science Association. This study was approved by the Institutional Review Board at the university where the survey was conducted. Our human subjects research was approved as "Exempt" by the IRB. At the beginning of the survey, respondents were presented with a consent form that provided basic information about the study and the estimated length of completion. Respondents were informed that they would not be asked to provide any identifying information when answering the survey. Respondents were provided with contact information for the survey administrator and the IRB office that approved the study.

The survey was conducted via Verasight. Payment was provided by Verasight and is in the form of points that respondents can redeem for rewards that include Venmo or PayPal payments, gift cards, or charitable donations. Respondents were selected from Verasight's opt-in panel. We have no reason to believe that the research benefited or harmed specific groups.

This research was financially supported by institutional funds. The code and data required to replicate all analyses will be provided through the relevant Dataverse upon publication of the article.

A.2 Survey Data Quality Procedures

Verasight takes a number of measures to ensure the quality of the responses to their surveys fielded on their platform. These procedures include multi-step authenticity verification of survey takers recruited to their platform, removing participants from their platform if they systematically exhibit low-quality behaviors (e.g., overly fast response times), and removing respondents from the survey if they fail attention checks or complete the survey in less than 30 percent of the median completion time. For more information, see https://www.verasight.io/why-verasight.

A.3 Survey Flow and Question Battery

Our design was part of a larger survey; the ordering of different parts of the survey was randomized in order to avoid systematic spillover effects. The order of our two experiments was also randomized to avoid spillover effects.

Before our treatments, we measured respondent partisan identification using the following two-part question. In our analyses, we code leaners as partisans.

- Generally speaking, do you think of yourself as a Republican, a Democrat, and Independent, or what? [Democrat/Republican/Independent/Other/Not sure]
  - If answered Democrat: Do you consider yourself a strong Democrat or a not so strong Democrat? [Strong Democrat/Not so strong Democrat]
  - If answered Republican: Do you consider yourself a strong Republican or a not so strong Republican? [Strong Republican/Not so strong Republican]
  - If answered Independent/Other/Not sure: Do you think of yourself as closer to the Democratic Party or the Republican Party? [Republican Party/Neither/Democratic Party]

To begin our first experiment, respondents were presented with the following prompt:

> As you know, President Trump won the 2024 election and took office in January 2025. Additionally, Republicans are in control of both chambers of Congress. Imagine that a Republican U.S. Senator who represents a state similar to yours sent the following letter to members of your community last week. Please read the statement carefully.

Then, respondents saw one of four statements about reducing federal waste: the control (generic statement), voicing support for the president's actions, an attempt to legislate, or success in legislating. The specific treatments are listed below. Varying text is presented in bold:

- (Control): Dear Neighbor, Thank you for taking the time to read about my work to serve as your Senator. One of my top priorities as your representative in Washington is cutting government waste. In recent years, waste and fraud has taken hold of the federal government. Republicans are working with President Trump and his administration to take action, and we won't stop fighting to bring the federal government's spending spree to a halt and uphold the rule of law. I will continue to work to support our country's needs every day.

- (Support for President): Dear Neighbor, Thank you for taking the time to read about my work to serve as your Senator. One of my top priorities as your representative in Washington is cutting government waste. In recent years, waste and fraud has taken hold of the federal government. **In just the past month, President Trump and his administration have issued a series of executive orders and administrative actions to identify and cut waste out of federal agencies. I am proud to support President Trump and his administration in these actions. I urge my fellow members of Congress to do so as well.** Republicans are working with President Trump and his administration to take action, and we won't stop fighting to bring the federal government's spending spree to a halt and uphold the rule of law. I will continue to work to support our country's needs every day.

- (Attempt to Legislate): Dear Neighbor, Thank you for taking the time to read about my work to serve as your Senator. One of my top priorities as your representative in Washington is cutting government waste. In recent years, waste and fraud has taken hold of the federal government. **In just the past month I introduced a new bill, the Prevent Taxpayer Waste Act, that takes steps to identify and cut waste out of federal agencies. I urge my colleagues to support this bill.** Republicans are working with President Trump and his administration to take action, and we won't stop fighting to bring the federal government's spending spree to a halt and uphold the rule of law. I will continue to work to support our country's needs every day.

- (Success in Legislating): Dear Neighbor, Thank you for taking the time to read about my work to serve as your Senator. One of my top priorities as your representative in Washington is cutting government waste. In recent years, waste and fraud has taken hold of the federal government. **In just the past month I introduced a new bill, the Prevent Taxpayer Waste Act, that takes steps to identify and cut waste out of federal agencies. I am proud to report that the bill passed in the Senate this week and I urge my colleagues in the House to act quickly and get this bill to President Trump's desk.** Republicans are working with President Trump and his administration to take action, and we won't stop fighting to bring the federal government's spending spree to a halt and uphold the rule of law. I will continue to work to support our country's needs every day.

Then, respondents answered our outcome questions:

- Do you approve of the way this member of Congress is doing their job? [Strongly approve/Somewhat approve/Neither approve nor disapprove/Somewhat disapprove/Strongly disapprove]

- This member of Congress works hard on behalf of people like me. [Strongly agree/Somewhat agree/Neither agree nor disagree/Somewhat disagree/Strongly disagree]

- I would vote for this member of Congress in the upcoming congressional election. [Strongly agree/Somewhat agree/Neither agree nor disagree/Somewhat disagree/Strongly disagree]

- Congress should play an active role in supporting the president. [Strongly agree/Somewhat agree/Neither agree nor disagree/Somewhat disagree/Strongly disagree]
- I approve of the job President Trump is doing to address the problems our country faces today. [Strongly agree/Somewhat agree/Neither agree nor disagree/Somewhat disagree/Strongly disagree]

To begin our second experiment, respondents were presented with the same prompt listed above. Then, respondents saw one of four statements about pushing back against the actions of the Trump administration: the control (generic statement), voicing disapproval of the president's action, a relatively weak attempt to legislate, or a relatively strong attempt to legislate. The specific treatments are listed below. Varying text is presented in bold:

- (Control): Dear Neighbor, Thank you for taking the time to read about my work to serve as your Senator. As you know, in just the past month the Trump administration has issued a series of executive orders and administrative actions that are unconstitutional and will impose dire consequences for folks across the country, including here in our state. This includes giving Elon Musk and DOGE control over how federal money is spent. Democrats are working together to stop President Trump and his administration, and we won't stop fighting to protect people's rights, protect our communities, and uphold the rule of law. I will continue to work to support our country's needs every day.
- (Opposition to President): Dear Neighbor, Thank you for taking the time to read about my work to serve as your Senator. As you know, in just the past month the Trump administration has issued a series of executive orders and administrative actions that are unconstitutional and will impose dire consequences for folks across the country, including here in our state. This includes giving Elon Musk and DOGE control over how federal money is spent. **Along with other Democrats, I have been vocal about my opposition to these actions taken by the Trump administration and will continue to express my disapproval of their reckless and dangerous behavior.** Democrats are working together to stop President Trump and his administration, and we won't stop fighting to protect people's rights, protect our communities, and uphold the rule of law. I will continue to work to support our country's needs every day.
- (Attempt to Legislate): Dear Neighbor, Thank you for taking the time to read about my work to serve as your Senator. As you know, in just the past month the Trump administration has issued a series of executive orders and administrative actions that are unconstitutional and will impose dire consequences for folks across the country, including here in our state. This includes giving Elon Musk and DOGE control over how federal money is spent. **I have introduced a new bill that takes steps to hold these people accountable for this reckless and dangerous behavior. The Taxpayer Protection Act is a bill**

that aims to prevent anyone with a conflict of interest or without the proper security clearance from accessing the federal payment system and sensitive data of millions of Americans. I urge my colleagues to support this bill. Democrats are working together to stop President Trump and his administration, and we won't stop fighting to protect people's rights, protect our communities, and uphold the rule of law. I will continue to work to support our country's needs every day.

- (Strong Attempt to Legislate): Dear Neighbor, Thank you for taking the time to read about my work to serve as your Senator. As you know, in just the past month the Trump administration has issued a series of executive orders and administrative actions that are unconstitutional and will impose dire consequences for folks across the country, including here in our state. This includes giving Elon Musk and DOGE control over how federal money is spent. **I have introduced a new bill that takes steps to hold these people accountable for this reckless and dangerous behavior. The Taxpayer Protection Act is a bill that aims to prevent anyone with a conflict of interest or without the proper security clearance from accessing the federal payment system and sensitive data of millions of Americans. I will be meeting with dozens of my colleagues in the upcoming days to urge them to cosponsor this important piece of legislation and get this bill through the legislative process and passed into law.** Democrats are working together to stop President Trump and his administration, and we won't stop fighting to protect people's rights, protect our communities, and uphold the rule of law. I will continue to work to support our country's needs every day.

Then, respondents answered the same outcome questions listed above with one adjustment—we asked respondents about Congress overseeing the president rather than supporting the president, given the different nature of this experiment. This question was asked as follows:

- Congress should play an active role in overseeing the behavior of the president. [Strongly agree/Somewhat agree/Neither agree nor disagree/Somewhat disagree/Strongly disagree]

TABLE A.1: Treatments of Legislator Reactions to Executive Policymaking

Condition	Language
Experiment 1 (Support)	
a. Control	In recent years, waste and fraud has taken hold of the federal government. **[Additional treatment language here.]** Republicans are working with President Trump and his administration to take action, and we won't stop fighting to bring the federal government's spending spree to a halt and uphold the rule of law.
b. Support for President	In just the past month, President Trump and his administration have issued a series of executive orders and administrative actions to identify and cut waste out of federal agencies. I am proud to support President Trump and his administration in these actions. I urge my fellow members of Congress to do so as well.
c. Attempt to Legislate	In just the past month I introduced a new bill, the Prevent Taxpayer Waste Act, that takes steps to identify and cut waste out of federal agencies. I urge my colleagues to support this bill.
d. Success in Legislating	In just the past month I introduced a new bill, the Prevent Taxpayer Waste Act, that takes steps to identify and cut waste out of federal agencies. I am proud to report that the bill passed in the Senate this week and I urge my colleagues in the House to act quickly and get this bill to President Trump's desk.
Experiment 2 (Opposition)	
a. Control	As you know, in just the past month the Trump administration has issued a series of executive orders and administrative actions that are unconstitutional and will impose dire consequences for folks across the country, including here in our state. This includes giving Elon Musk and DOGE control over how federal money is spent. **[Additional treatment language here.]** Democrats are working together to stop President Trump and his administration, and we won't stop fighting to protect people's rights, protect our communities, and uphold the rule of law.
b. Opposition to President	Along with other Democrats, I have been vocal about my opposition to these actions taken by the Trump administration and will continue to express my disapproval of their reckless and dangerous behavior.
c. Attempt to Legislate	I have introduced a new bill that takes steps to hold these people accountable for this reckless and dangerous behavior. The Taxpayer Protection Act is a bill that aims to prevent anyone with a conflict of interest or without the proper security clearance from accessing the federal payment system and sensitive data of millions of Americans. I urge my colleagues to support this bill.
d. Strong Attempt to Legislate	I have introduced a new bill that takes steps to hold these people accountable for this reckless and dangerous behavior. The Taxpayer Protection Act is a bill that aims to prevent anyone with a conflict of interest or without the proper security clearance from accessing the federal payment system and sensitive data of millions of Americans. I will be meeting with dozens of my colleagues in the upcoming days to urge them to cosponsor this important piece of legislation and get this bill through the legislative process and passed into law.

Note: All respondents received the text of the Control statement, those in treatment conditions received the additional text noted in the table.

A.4 Descriptive Statistics

TABLE A.2: Descriptive Statistics: April 2025 Verasight Survey

Variable	N	Percent
Gender	1999	
... Female	1050	53%
... Male	938	47%
... Other	11	1%
Race	1999	
... Asian or Asian-American	100	5%
... Black or African-American	254	13%
... Mixed race	102	5%
... Native American or American Indian	45	2%
... Pacific Islander	8	0%
... Some other race	70	4%
... White	1420	71%
Party	1990	
... Democrat	776	39%
... Other/Not Sure	128	6%
... Republican	786	39%
... True Independent	300	15%
Education	2000	
... Some high school or less	91	5%
... High school graduate or GED	608	30%
... Some college, no degree	349	17%
... 2-year or associate degree	184	9%
... 4-year or bachelor degree	486	24%
... Post-graduate degree	282	14%
Income	1999	
... Less than $15,000	244	12%
... $15,000 to under $50,000	384	19%
... $50,000 to under $75,000	531	27%
... $75,000 to under $100,000	325	16%
... $100,000 to under $150,000	291	15%
... $150,000 to under $200,000	133	7%
... More than $200,000	91	5%
Ideology	1994	
... Conservative	400	20%
... Liberal	361	18%
... Moderate	843	42%
... Very Conservative	182	9%
... Very Liberal	208	10%
Region	1973	
... Midwest	420	21%
... Northeast	330	17%
... South	774	39%
... West	449	23%

Note: Table presents information on characteristics of sample respondents. Full sample N = 2,000. Respondents who did not answer the relevant question are coded as NA and not reported in the table.

B Examples of Real-World Legislator Communication

Our experimental treatments were inspired by real-world communication from members of Congress directed toward their constituents. Table B.1 presents examples of these communications.

TABLE B.1: Legislator Public Messaging Examples

Legislator	Relevant Condition(s)	Language
Rep. Joe Neguse (D, CO-2)	Control, Attempt to Legislate	"Earlier this week, House Minority Leader Hakeem Jeffries announced the creation of a Litigation Working Group and Rapid Response Task Force, which he has asked me to lead and serve as chairman of the effort. I'm honored to do so. As you know, in just the past month the Trump administration has issued a series of executive orders and administrative actions that are unconstitutional and will impose dire consequences for folks across the country, including here in Colorado. These actions warrant a decisive response, which is why our Task Force will work together to develop comprehensive legislative, oversight and legal strategies."
Rep. Dan Meuser (R, PA-9)	Success in Legislating	"I am pleased to report that H.R. 35, the Agent Raul Gonzalez Officer Safety Act, passed in the House this week with bipartisan support... H.R. 35 establishes federal criminal penalties for individuals who intentionally evade Border Patrol or other law enforcement, with harsher consequences when such actions result in serious injury or death... I urge my colleagues in the Senate to act quickly and get this bill to President Trump's desk... House Republicans are working with President Trump and his administration to take action-and we won't stop fighting to secure our border, protect our communities, and uphold the rule of law."
Sen. Jim Banks (R-IN)	Support for President	"Thankfully, the America First Trade Policy that the Trump administration has laid out recognizes how vital the steel industry is for our prosperity. President Trump knows we need to reinvigorate our trade agenda to promote investment, productivity, and security, and make sure our producers are treated fairly. The days of foreign companies cheating and trampling on the American worker are OVER. President Trump means business and he's got an administration and a Senate majority that stand with him."
Rep. Mike Levin (D, CA-49)	Opposition to President	"While I am all for a good faith effort to tackle waste, fraud, and abuse in government, that's not what Elon Musk and DOGE are doing. Instead, they are dismantling federal agencies that provide services Americans rely on and trying to eliminate Congress's power of the purse. View my Floor speeches on standing up for checks and balances here and here."

Note: Table presents examples of legislator messaging about efforts to oppose or support the Trump administration. Statements come from e-newsletters. The full text of this discussion can be viewed for Neguse (here), Meuser (here), Banks (here), and Levin (here).

C Discussion of Pre-Analysis Plan

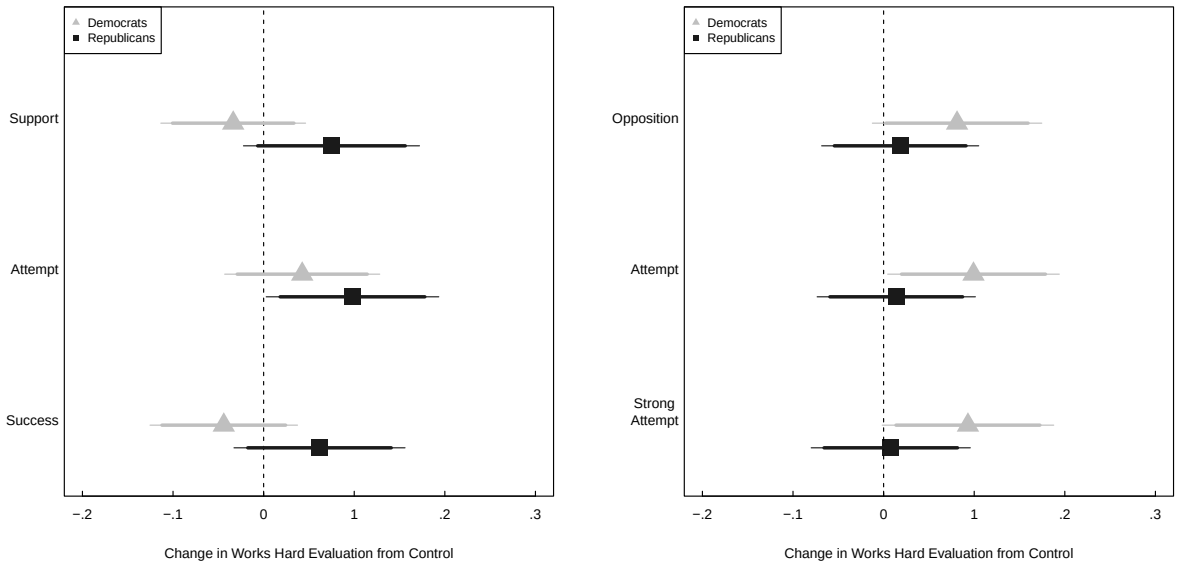
Our pre-analysis plan is available at https://aspredicted.org/c93y-3x75.pdf. Our design and data collection procedures followed our plan. We follow our plan in our main text and Appendix analyses.

D Additional Empirical Analyses

D.1 Legislator Works Hard on Behalf of Constituents

FIGURE D.1: Legislator Action and Evaluations of Legislator Work

(a) Experiment 1 (Support for President) **(b)** Experiment 2 (Opposition to President)

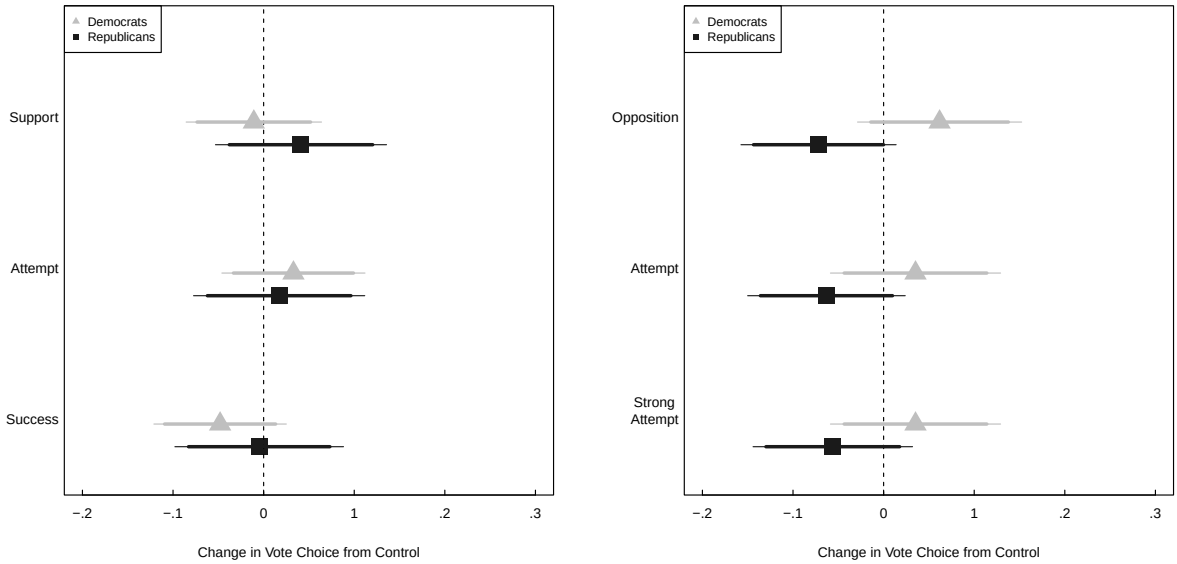


Note: Left panel shows estimated treatment effects on binary agreement with statement that legislator works hard on behalf of constituents as function of legislator action as compared to control statement. Right panel shows estimated treatment effects on binary agreement with statement that legislator works hard on behalf of constituents as function of legislator action as compared to control statement. 90 and 95 percent confidence intervals plotted for each estimate.

D.2 Vote Choice

FIGURE D.2: Legislator Action and Vote Choice

(a) Experiment 1 (Support for President) **(b)** Experiment 2 (Opposition to President)

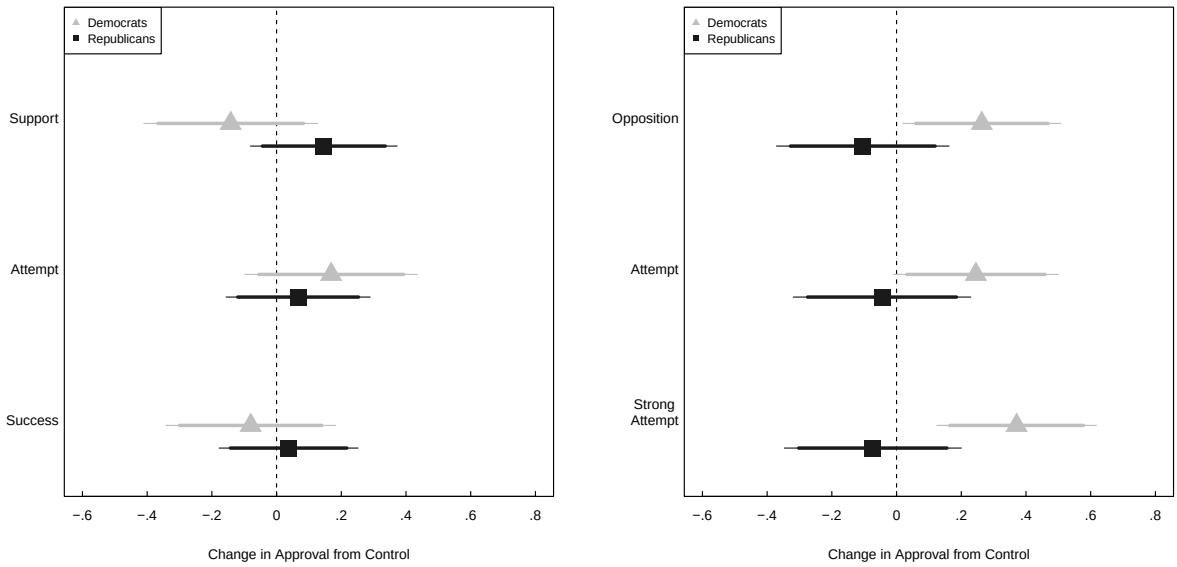


Note: Left panel shows estimated treatment effects on binary vote choice as function of legislator action as compared to control statement. Right panel shows estimated treatment effects on binary vote choice as function of legislator action as compared to control statement. 90 and 95 percent confidence intervals plotted for each estimate.

D.3 Legislator Approval (Five-Point Measure)

FIGURE D.3: Legislator Action and Approval of Legislator (Five-Point Measure)

(a) Experiment 1 (Support for President) **(b)** Experiment 2 (Opposition to President)

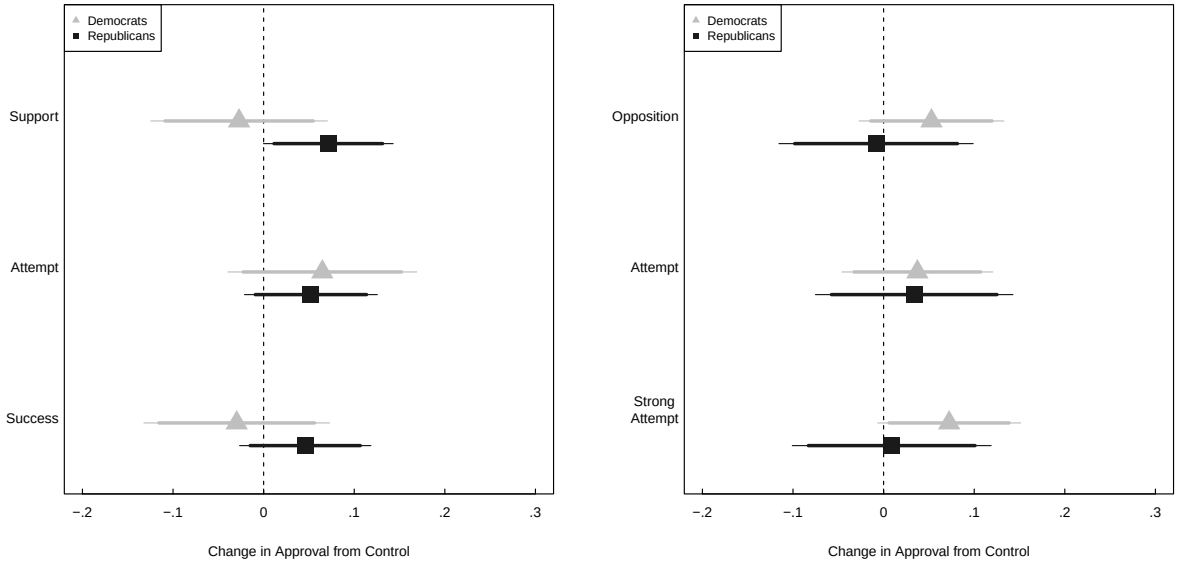


Note: Left panel shows estimated treatment effects on approval of Republican legislators as function of legislator action as compared to control statement. Right panel shows estimated treatment effects on approval of Democratic legislators as function of legislator action as compared to control statement. Outcome variable is five-point measure of approval; higher values indicate greater support. 90 and 95 percent confidence intervals plotted for each estimate.

D.4 Legislator Approval (Drop Middle-Ground Respondents)

FIGURE D.4: Legislator Action and Approval of Legislator (Drop Middle-Ground Respondents)

(a) Experiment 1 (Support for President) **(b)** Experiment 2 (Opposition to President)



Note: Left panel shows estimated treatment effects on approval of Republican legislators as function of legislator action as compared to control statement. Right panel shows estimated treatment effects on approval of Democratic legislators as function of legislator action as compared to control statement. Outcome variable is binary measure of approval; respondents who answered "neither approve nor disapprove" are dropped from the analyses. 90 and 95 percent confidence intervals plotted for each estimate.